way round. Congress simply couldn't match the organisation of BJP.'[60]

For BJP leaders, the fundamental difference between them and their opponents is the 'importance of organisation'. 'The difference on the ground is the importance of the karyakarta. In the Congress and the JD-S, they are only active when elections come. Even if there are no elections, we are doing our work regularly,' says Ravi Kumar.

A Party Office in Each District

Politics is often about ideas. But ideas by themselves cannot effect change. They need to be disseminated effectively, else they remain ineffectual. This is why a political party's organisational structures are as important as its ideology. As the American general Omar Bradley put it, 'Amateurs talk strategy. Professionals talk logistics.'

Building the logistical structure required to power its organisation is precisely what the BJP has focused on since winning the general election in 2014. 'Victories in elections are often achieved,' Amit Shah has argued, 'but strengthening the organisation in a sustained manner is a much more difficult task and this is the opportune period when we have won elections … We have to lay the firm foundation so that for the next hundred years the BJP can emerge as a mighty and magnificent edifice.'[61]

The most visible marker of what the BJP's leaders mean by a 'firm foundation' lies in their decision to buy land and build party offices in almost every Indian district. In its national executive meeting in April 2015, the party made a decision to own an office in 635 of the country's 694 districts.[62] A measure of the ambition of this task is that, until 2017, it owned land for offices in only 190 districts (27 per cent of India).[63] Since then, it has focused on achieving this goal at breakneck speed.

Karnataka is a good case study for how this process unfolded. 'In two years, we will build our own offices in all thirty districts of the state,' Ravi Kumar declared confidently to me in February 2020. We were meeting in his office at the party's brand-new building in Bengaluru. I had asked him how the party was moving along on